owned the movie theaters of America. But there was still a part of me that wanted to be a motion picture actor, and in 1964 I made my last picture—*The Killers*.

For the first time in my acting career, I played a villain—and the reaction may have proven that Jack Warner had something when he kept casting me as the good guy in those drawing-room comedies.

The Killers was a remake of a 1946 picture starring Burt Lancaster that was based on an Ernest Hemingway story. I had seen the original picture and hadn't liked it very much because everybody in the script was a villain and there was no one to root for.

When Universal asked me to play a gangster in the remake of *The Killers*, my instinct was to say no. But I'm afraid they took advantage of an actor's ego:

"But you've never played a villain before," they said.

It was a challenge no actor could resist. I said, "Okay, I'll do it."

A lot of people who went to see *The Killers*, I'm told, kept waiting for me to turn out to be a good guy in the end and dispatch the villains in the last reel, because that's how they had always seen me before. But I didn't, and for whatever reason, the picture didn't ring many bells at the box office.

Although my movie career was coming to a close, I was still receiving lots of offers to act as a guest star in television shows. Before long I agreed to do another series, as host—and occasional actor—in "Death Valley Days."

If I wasn't scheduled to act in a show, I'd drive down to the studio from our ranch, spend an hour or so taping an introduction for the next show, then drive home; some days, I didn't even have to get out of my ranch clothes for the filming.

The job left me plenty of time for speeches and Republican activities, and when I was asked to be the cochairman of Barry Gold-water's 1964 presidential campaign in California,